police notice on events, and the station aired a brief report at 8:25 a.m. In the USSR such an initiative by an independent radio station was unthinkable, but in the United States it was unremarkable. By 9:00 a.m. the Associated Press had issued a bulletin. Though it took days for the full details to emerge, American citizens learned about the accident two hours after it was first noticed. Subsequent investigations by government agencies, NGOs, academics and the press uncovered not just the immediate causes of the accident but also its deeper structural causes, which helped improve the safety of nuclear technology worldwide. Indeed, some of the lessons of Three Mile Island, which were openly shared even with the Soviets, contributed to mitigating the Chernobyl disaster.[112]

NOBODY'S PERFECT

Totalitarian and authoritarian networks face other problems besides blocked arteries. First and foremost, as we have already established, their self-correcting mechanisms tend to be very weak. Since they believe they are infallible, they see little need for such mechanisms, and since they are afraid of any independent institution that might challenge them, they lack free courts, media outlets or research centres. Consequently, there is nobody to expose and correct the daily abuses of power that characterise all governments. The leader may occasionally proclaim an anti-corruption campaign, but in nondemocratic systems these often turn out to be little more than a smoke screen for one regime faction to purge another faction.[113]

And what happens if the leader himself embezzles public funds or makes some disastrous policy mistake? Nobody can challenge the leader, and on his own initiative the leader – being a human being – may well refuse to admit any mistakes. Instead, he is likely to blame all problems on 'foreign enemies', 'internal traitors' or 'corrupt subordinates' and demand even more power in order to deal with the alleged malefactors.

For example, we mentioned in the previous chapter that Stalin adopted the bogus theory of Lysenkoism as the state doctrine on evolution. The results were catastrophic. Neglect of Darwinian models and attempts by Lysenkoist agronomists to create super-crops set back Soviet genetic research for decades and undermined Soviet agriculture. Soviet experts who